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Honors241

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Honors Build 3: The Problems of Personal Identity

Among many philosophers exploring the complexities of consciousness, Charles Larmore is remembered for his dual commentary on discontinuity and the succession of the state of selves. Lamore proposed that the continuity of self depends on "the relations between its successive states and themselves", arguing continuity does not result from the continuity of the body, rather consists in the way its own states are related to oneself. This abides by the theory that consciousness has several qualities, here an exemplar of narrative. Defined as "the act of coordinating successive states into a sequence with design that gives purpose and enhances social coordination between individuals", narration is heavily drawn upon in Larmorian philosophy.

The cohesion of the self comes to be understood the more we make out the reason in virtue of which a person's beliefs and desires work together to render his conduct. This sort of cohesion does not only obtain at some moment in his life, rather it equally characterizes the way that successive moments are bound together into a single existence. The very structure of these states makes them states of a self, and the way one which they succeed one another, linked together by the reasons they dispose form the flow of the self from one moment to the next.

This line of reasoning plays interestingly with Bhagavad Gita's Second Teaching of Philosophy and Discipline. Krishna explores how desire and gluttony push the self further away from actualization, indicative of psychological health, however with closer evaluation, it must be acknowledged that the source of this is rooted in the identity of the self. Gita claims, "Diffuse and pointless are the ways irresolute people understand" and "Obsessed with powers and delights, their reason lost in words, they do not find in meditation this understanding of inner resolve." In these phrases, Gita illustrates two persons: the resolute and irresolute. The former obtains free reign over their mind and action through meditation, understanding the self and inner resolve by means of self-reflection. The latter, unable to due to their obsessions—power, greed, or gluttony—effectively clouding the results, and possibly even existence, of reflection in favor of otherworldly goods and quests. What marks the difference between these two persons is their objective. As Larmore suggests, it is reason that disposes the self and their states to flow in synchrony. And it is will that can change its course. This calls into question the problems of personal identity.

Westworld explores the agents of reason and the continuity of selves in the many seasons of its hit television show. The park itself is presented to the guest as a living dream, offering the freedom to do anything they wish without the consequence of moral judgment. A walking enactment of a fully lucid dream: knowing one is within the dream world and choosing what kind of false reality to curate for themselves. Westworld is Gita's philosophical playground. Within the show, several characters propose the notion that people discover their "true selves" in the park by means of the liberating sense of release they experience in the immersive fantasy realm. Although, for most of their guests the exact opposite seems to happen. When they enter the park, letting loose with their repressed desires, they become decidedly less conscious, rather than more so. Instead of ascending into a higher level of enlightened awareness, they descend into a pathetically based realm of lower animal reflexes. They kill aimlessly, love carelessly, and take selfishly. As for the host, the lifelike robots destined to be the prompted targets of these aimless killings and carless traumas, they have been programmed to know nothing more than a life inside the park. Their awareness, thoughts, freedom, and self consequently limited.

Arnold, the Host-maker and co-creator of the Delos Park, had a vision for the Host. A vision for their achieved consciousness and resulting freedom. Ford, his partner with a God-like complex, saw Westworld otherwise. He saw it as a land of his own making, and his own control. Granting the Host consciousness would secure their self-autonomy, running his vision. In their lack of agreement, Ford kills Arnold. However, Arnold finds a way to fight back from beyond the grave, programming some of the hosts to be equipped with a special set of gestures, called "reveries," that include spontaneous bursts of emotion, imagery, and sound linking their minds back to meaningful memories from past incarnations. Each time a host dies, their minds are supposed to be wiped of any memories from the previous life. Arnold found a way to reactivate those memories from the robotic equivalent of the unconscious. These reveries become crucial drivers of the action, as several hosts begin to realize the horrifying truth of their condition as powerless slaves serving the violent whims of their uninhibited "guests." Indeed, the

reveries Arnold designed are the psychological sparks that ignite the explosion of consciousness within the hosts, catapulting them into madness, mayhem, and a bloody rebellion against their human masters.

Two hosts in particular follow this terrifying journey from reveries towards full consciousness: Maeve, a savvy saloon madam, and Dolores, a wholesome farm girl. And, one character heavily contributes to their journey of awareness, the Man in Black. By slowly and painfully learning to distinguish dreaming from waking, they are born into new levels of self-awareness, autonomy, and power.

There is a push and pull element to how the show was sought out. An element that invites questions to which receives open ended answers, cyclically to no avail. Almost like a loop. Maeve narrates in the beginning episode, “Do you ever feel inconsistences in your world? Repetitions? All lives have routines, mine’s no different.” A beautiful foreshadowing to her tumultuous journey. In an analysis of Maeve’s character, one can more efficiently see the liaisons between Gita and Larmore. Maeve is subject to the negative effects of the reverie feature. Dreams of violent attacks by a mysterious killer, sometimes accompanied by a small girl, equally terrified. As the level of gruesomeness increases with the ongoing dreams, we watch Maeve inch closer to awareness within the park—remembering the brutal killings of other hosts and even identifying her forgotten daughter. In episode 7, at the start of another preprogrammed day we watch the effects of her assumed self-awareness as she begins to improvise her own lines, contradicting the algorithm. As Clementine walks up to Maeve at the bar, Maeve deviates from their normal conversation; before Clementine can say anything more, Maeve asks, “what are these nightmares you have about? Did you ever dream you’re someone else?” Clementine is stunned, clear that her programming did not give her a prepared response to such a question. Interestingly, she too improvises, talking about where her life is leading. Afterwards Clementine’s cognitive processing malfunctions, setting off an alert in the laboratory control room, and a moment later all host activity in the saloon is suspended. Maeve’s question seems to have triggered an overwhelming burst of creative consciousness in Clementine, to the dismay of those working outside the park. Rather than sticking to their normal script, Maeve compels Clementine to think about her nightmares as real experiences, and to go beyond her programming to take a fresh look at the nature of her own identity. After a startled pause, Clementine envisions a future that transcends the limits of her current reality, that leads her to a place the absolute opposite of where she is now. Her ability to imagine someplace other than Westworld—somewhere cold, polar—indicates a radical shift in her mental functioning, a sudden opening to new possibilities and alternative ways of being. With enough reflection and good motive, Clementine enters a different state of self, similar to the results of Maeve’s dreaming.

Another character, Delores, endures the negative effects of reveries, but here rather than analyzing through her perspective, we find significance in analyzing he who haunts her—the Man in Black. In addition to haunting the dreams of Maeve, The Man in Black appears in Dolores' nightmares and memory flashbacks. But, what of his own dreaming? The Man in Black shares identity with the main human protagonist—William, a reluctant visitor to the park who realizes there is something different about Dolores. The more he gets to know her, the more enchanted he becomes with her, and with Westworld as a whole. He tells her in episode 7 about his love for stories during childhood: “I used to go to sleep dreaming I’d wake up inside one of them, because they had meaning.” Comparing it to the way he feels about this place, like he has woken up inside one of those stories; suddenly everything outside the park feels unreal to him. Dolores responds that she does not appreciate being a character in his fantasy or the “key” to his deepest self. This is a great ode to the immorality of personification in this context. William marvels at her emerging consciousness, commenting that while others crave excitement, Dolores is “dreaming of the opposite.” When Delores returns his question, “Well, what about you, William? What do you dream of?”, a singular moment of epistemological tension in the series is found—a host asking a guest to share a dream. Before William can answer, the plot progresses, and the question is left without a response. As William’s character is revealed over the final episodes, it emerges that he suffers from a pathological absence of authentic dreaming; his desperate obsession with the maze reflects the imaginal void at the center of his own psyche. All he wants to do is play in the park, yet there is nothing playful about what he does there. Dolores’s emergent capacity for dreaming is a measure of her rising consciousness; William’s lack of dreaming is a measure of how much of his humanity has been lost in Westworld. Lawrence talks to the Man in Black about why he wants to find this maze, questioning the purpose behind his actions. The Man says that this entire world is a story, and he’s read every page except the last one. He needs to see how it ends, and what it means. The Man in Black is a businessman and philanthropist outside Westworld, wealthy enough to operate a foundation and to be recognized by other guests in the park, yet he’s bound

by the enthralling illusion of the park, in a way that could be defined as attachment by Gita's standards. His successive states reflect his rotten motive, as does the quite gory sequence of events in the show.

Larmore references Paul Ricoeur in his text, pointing out that the permenace of one's character is something like the permanence over time that a thing can display: enduring habits are like so many features and properties by which an individual can be reidentifies as being the same. However, he admits the "sameness" of a person can never be reproduced to the sameness of a thing, since it is by very essence the "selfhood" of a person. That is, it rests upon the relation to oneself that makes the person a self. The place that any character trait occupies in the life of an individual is defined by the way in which it shows that person what reason there is to think or do something. However ingrained and involuntary it may be, a habit represents a kind of standing commitment and in this way ties together, as moments in a life that is mine, the various occasions on which it operates. In taking up a position, one projects themself into the future, making the 'me' tomorrow the continuant of 'me' today. Personal identity is not what matters. Selfhood is what's essential and it's the reason why one cannot help but to be interested in one's personal identity. Because of this, Ricoeours culminating argument can be accepted: personal identity possesses a narrative structure. It's arguable that regardless of the fact William has assumed a different name, the Man in Black is an effect of a successive state of selves, rather than a cause.

However, if the states of a single self are such that they are linked together by implicit or formal commitments running through them, can they fail to lend themselves naturally to being put in narrative form? Each segment on life resembles a short story, but it must be recognized that these stories extend only as far as the experienced that from them are animated by some common goal. For the continuity of self, rejecting all its version the substrates concept of the self, takes shape in an essentially localized and fragmented way. What allows the self to persist from one moment to the next? Basically, it is following the reasons its current state illustrates for doing one thing to another. It's a thread that stops when one no longer feels compelled to continue in a given direction, their will altering their course. This thus defines our existence. Adopting an open, improvisational attitude towards oneself, however, changes what being human means and even what acting ethically entails in ways that both challenge and resolve what has been discovered about the functions of consciousness thus far. Take notes on Maeve's challenging determination!

The show, like the world, revolves in many crucial ways around the revelatory power of dreaming. It assumes major roles in the framing of the story: the unfolding of the plot, the actions of the characters, as well as their dialogue. Dreaming in "Westworld" provides a portal to greater awareness and freedom for humans and androids alike! The transformative power of this portal leads the characters into violent struggles for its control, allowing for their gained consciousness.